We Moved Her to a Big Kid Bed and It Was Chaos (Then Fine)

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We moved our daughter to a big kid bed the weekend she turned three, because she'd started climbing out of the crib like a tiny escape artist and I was terrified she'd break her neck at 2am. The crib had kept her in. The bed, it turned out, kept nothing in.

Night one, she was in our bedroom at 11:40pm, standing next to my side of the bed, just staring at me. I woke up, screamed, she screamed, my husband woke up and screamed. Great start.

The first week was chaos. She'd appear in the hallway at midnight, at 1:30, at 4:15 — silent, like a little ghost, just standing there. We'd walk her back, tuck her in, and twenty minutes later: ghost again. By night four I was crying in the kitchen at 3am eating cereal out of the box, convinced we'd ruined sleep forever.

My first idea flopped hard: the big hype speech. "You're such a BIG girl in your BIG bed!" with jazz hands. She saw right through it. Night two she said "I don't want to be big" and honestly, fair.

What actually helped came in two parts. First, the okay-to-wake clock — the little one that turns green at 6:30. We made a huge deal out of the rule, not the bed: "when it's green, you can come out. When it's not green, your job is to stay in bed." She took to it like it was a game. The first morning it turned green she ran into our room yelling "IT'S GREEN IT'S GREEN" and I have never been so happy to be woken up.

Second, the mattress on the floor. For two weeks we just put her mattress directly on the floor next to the bed frame. No fall risk, no drama, and somehow it made the whole thing feel less like a cliff edge. When she wandered, she'd just… lie back down on the floor mattress. Then one Saturday she asked us to put it "up high like a real bed" and that was that.

Total chaos duration: about ten days. Then fine. Then better than the crib, because bedtime stories in a big bed with room for me to lie next to her are genuinely lovely.

One more thing nobody warned me about: my husband started falling asleep in her bed during the bedtime story. I'd go in at 10pm to check on her and find them both out cold, him folded into a toddler bed like a pretzel, her starfished across his chest. We started calling it "the transfer" — I'd wake him up and we'd tiptoe out together. It lasted a month. Honestly? Those were some of my favorite nights of the whole year. Tired, quiet, everybody exactly where they were supposed to be.

If you're about to do this: skip the hype speech. Get the clock. And don't be proud about the mattress on the floor — nobody's watching, and it works.